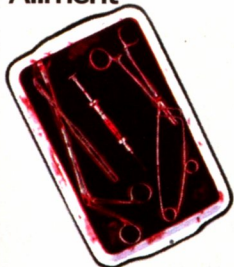


1

Ailment



The most common medical blunder in India. Scissors, gauze, towels, screws, forceps, metal clamps—the list of objects surgeons leave behind inside patients' bodies is alarming.

WHAT SURGEONS FORGET

"It's one of the most persistent but poorly understood medical errors," says Dr Arvind Kumar, professor of surgery at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). New research shows that certain factors increase the risk of such mistakes. A 2003 study on 29 million surgeries published in *The New England Journal of Medicine* showed that items are more likely to be left inside in an emergency surgery or if there's an unexpected change in procedure. The former was found to increase the risk of this type of error ninefold and the latter fourfold.

Prescription

Apart from stricter laws to penalise offending surgeons and heavy compensation for patients, hospitals need to streamline operation procedures.

2

Ailment



Don't treat a nose job or a breast augmentation as simple lunch-time procedures. These are real surgeries with the real risk of disfiguring your forever.

COSMETIC GOOF-UP

"Cosmetic surgery patients consider themselves consumers, not patients," says Dr Sunil Chaudhary, head of aesthetic & reconstructive plastic surgery, Max Healthcare, Delhi. The five common cosmetic surgery mishaps are: inappropriate doses of botox injection that cause expressionless faces; cheaper breast implants that rupture or leak; excessive skin stretching during facelifts, giving a too-tight look; large volume liposuctions done in ill-equipped clinics that lead to fluid overload in the body and serious heart-lung complications; aggressive removal of nose cartilage, giving a pinched appearance.

Prescription

The Medical Council of India (MCI) must blacklist quacks and de-recognise such surgeons; patients need to be empowered with information on safety standards.

3

Ailment



Doctors amputating the wrong foot or removing the wrong kidney—hundreds of such surgical gaffes occur every year.

REMOVING WRONG PARTS

An urban myth? Think again. There was a stream of reports last year on such surgical gaffes. This month, in a tragic mix-up, blood transfusion meant for one patient was given to another in a premier Delhi hospital as his bed had changed, causing severe blood reaction. "Most of these happen because doctors don't listen," says Dr Prashant P. Joshi, cardiologist with the IG Government Medical College in Nagpur. "A study shows 90 per cent doctors interrupt patients in the first 20 seconds of their conversation." Besides that, in wrong-site surgery, several factors almost certainly come into play, from a series of small but crucial mistakes by several people who dealt with the patient to flaws in a hospital's operating procedures. "It is individuals making several mistakes and systems not being able to prevent those mistakes," adds Joshi.

Prescription

Apart from criminal action against rogue surgeons and hospitals, the MCI should cancel licences of the doctors involved. Also upgrading the checks in place for such operations is the urgent need of the hour.